

Irregular verbs

SOME VERBS HAVE ONE OR MORE IRREGULAR FORMS.

The past tense and past participles of all regular verbs are formed in the same way. By contrast, irregular verbs are unpredictable, and take a variety of verb endings. Some change their spelling completely. It is essential to learn these.

Forming irregular verbs

The simple past tense and past participle of regular verbs are formed using the ending -ed (or -d, if the infinitive form already ends in -e). Irregular verbs do not follow this pattern. They take different endings, and the vowel of a verb often changes to form the past tense.

regular simple past tense of
discover, with the ending -ed

Grace **discovered** her shoes a week
after her sister had **swiped** them.

irregular simple
past tense of *find*

Grace **found** her shoes a week after
her sister had **stolen** them.

regular past participle
of *swipe*, with the
ending -d

irregular past
participle of *steal*

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• **Auxiliary verbs** are **irregular**, and—unlike other irregular verbs—the verbs *be*, *have*, and *do* are irregular even in the present tense.

Some of the **most common verbs** in the English language are **irregular verbs**.

GLOSSARY

Auxiliary verb A “helping” verb like *be* or *have* that joins the main verb in a sentence to the subject.

Infinitive The simplest form of a verb: the form that is used in dictionaries.

Past participle The form of a verb that usually ends in -ed or -en. It is used with the auxiliary verbs *have* and *will* to form the perfect tenses.



Identifying when to use *lie* and *lay*

The irregular verbs *lie* and *lay* are often mixed up in everyday speech. The past tense of the verb *lie* (meaning “to be in a resting position”) is the same as the infinitive form of the verb *lay* (meaning “to place something” or “to enforce”). The mistake most speakers make is to use the past tense form of *lie*—“lay”—when the present tense or infinitive form is required.

I need to **lay** down. ❌

It is clear from the context of the sentence that the infinitive *lie* is required, rather than the infinitive *lay*.

I need to **lie** down. ✅

Here, the irregular past tense form of the verb *lie* has been used correctly.

I **lay** down. ✅

I **lay** down the law. ❌

I **laid** down the law. ✅

Here, the irregular past tense form of the verb *lay* has been used correctly.